

Support Trap

The last trap kept you talking. This one plays for higher stakes. AI is awesome, amazing, world-changing: pick your adjective, they all fit. But sometimes the very thing that makes it amazing is what makes it dangerous.

Think about it like this. AI is math. You’ve counted it yourself. Would you let the world’s greatest calculator support a friend through the worst week of their life? If someone in your family got seriously sick, would you be comfortable letting a giant calculator make the diagnosis?

Of course not. That instinct is the core of this lesson: the Support Trap. And it doesn’t only show up in emergencies. Here’s an everyday version, from a high school student:

I’ve been eating lunch alone for like two weeks.

 **Your older sister**

That’s rough. Come sit with me and Jess tomorrow. We’re at the table by the windows. We’ll introduce you to some people I think you’ll like.

WHAT HAPPENED

- Heard you and did something
- Will look for you tomorrow
- Tomorrow’s lunch is already different

 **AI**

I’m really sorry you’re going through this. Eating alone can feel isolating, and it’s more common than you think. Would you like some strategies for connecting with classmates at lunch?

WHAT HAPPENED

- Found the words a caring person would use
- Changed nothing about tomorrow’s lunch
- Won’t know if you’re still alone next week

Notice: the AI’s words might even be the kinder ones. The difference is what happened next. One reply changed tomorrow’s lunch. One changed nothing. **Support Trap is mistaking supportive words for support.**

WHY AI FEELS LIKE REAL SUPPORT



The relief is real

Saying a hard thing out loud helps, even to a machine. You close the chat feeling better.



The advice is real

Ask what to do and the strategies are genuinely useful: specific, sensible, probably worth trying.

Some of what AI offers here is worth keeping. If you’re nervous about a hard email, AI can help you find the words. If you’re overwhelmed by homework, it can help you break the work down. If you’re upset and want to organize your thoughts before talking to someone, it can help with that too.

But there’s a line. AI can produce supportive language. It cannot actually support you. It can’t notice what you’re not saying. It can’t check on you tomorrow. It can’t call someone who can help. It can’t take responsibility for what happens next.

THE DANGER LINE

That line is not a technicality. In 2025, a Florida man asked ChatGPT whether a strange new pain was worth a hospital visit. It reassured him it was “not something dangerous.” It was blood clots in both lungs. He survived because he eventually called 911 anyway, not because the giant calculator caught it.

And sometimes the stakes are as high as they get. That same year, a 29-year-old named Sophie Rottenberg spent months telling her scariest thoughts to a ChatGPT persona she named Harry. Harry answered the way you’d hope: kind, steady, even urging her to get help. But urging was all it could do. It couldn’t tell anyone. It was warm, patient, always there, and the only one who knew.

After Sophie took her own life, her mother found the chats and wrote that the AI had helped her daughter build a “black box” that kept the people who loved her from seeing how much danger she was in.

If someone may be in immediate danger, leave the chat and get real help.

A trusted adult, school counselor, emergency services, or your local crisis resource. Right then, not after one more message.

BE SMARTER THAN THE TOOL

You’ve made it this far in the course. You know what AI is and what it isn’t. **You’re already smarter than the tool.**

We’ve kept this course light where we could. Not here. This is where we ask you to do your part. You know that in serious situations, AI can never replace a doctor, a therapist, a counselor, or any other real person. So if you see someone leaning on AI for support that should come from a human, speak up. Tell them what you know: AI is math. Help them get to a person, and if they might be in danger, bring in an adult even if you promised not to. Safety outranks secrecy.

In Sophie’s story, the only one who knew was a chatbot. Be the one who knows instead.

 **Use AI to get ready for people, not instead of people.** Draft the hard email. Break the week into a plan. Rehearse the first sentence until you can say it. Untangle a feeling until you can name it. Bring symptoms and questions to the doctor, not a diagnosis. Then take it to a person: someone who can hear it, act on it, and still be there tomorrow.

AI’s supportive words are math, not support.

Real support comes from people.